the EU's pro-migrant policies as threats to European identity and defending Christianity as the continent's cultural foundation.[4] Beyond migration, Orbán has opposed globalist measures, including aid packages to Ukraine, while forging alliances with populist and authoritarian leaders such as Donald Trump, Jair Bolsonaro, and Giorgia Meloni.

To amplify his influence, Orbán has weaponized Hungary's voting power within EU institutions, such as the European Council and Parliament. He has also cultivated alliances with states like Poland, the Czech Republic, and Slovakia, collectively known as the Visegrad Four, to resist EU efforts to discipline members that backslide on democratic principles.[5] Orbán's close ties with Russia and China further bolster his anti-democratic credentials while enhancing his leverage within the EU; Hungary remained the sole EU member maintaining close relations with Russia following its 2022 invasion of Ukraine.[6]

Faced with Orbán's disruptions, the EU has pursued a dual strategy of appeasement and sidelining. Appeasement has often been used to secure Hungary's cooperation on critical initiatives. During negotiations over the Multiannual Financial Framework and COVID-19 recovery fund in 2020, the EU agreed to dilute governance conditions aimed at ensuring that funds were not misused by member states.[7] The compromise included a two-step mechanism for addressing rule-of-law violations (Ladi and Wolff 2021), which critics argue diluted the impact of conditionality measures.[8] Proponents, however, defend the move as a necessary concession to preserve EU cohesion and avoid a deadlock.[9]

At the same time, the EU has not shied away from sidelining Hungary when appeasement has failed. For instance, when Hungary blocked a €50 billion aid package for Ukraine in 2023, the EU devised alternative financing mechanisms to bypass Budapest's veto, including the use of debt and carry-over plans.[10] Similarly, after Hungary left the UN Global Compact for Migration in 2018, the EU developed an "EU-minus-Hungary" negotiation strategy (Schuette and Dijkstra 2023), effectively isolating Orbán's government from key discussions.

Legal action has also been a recurring tool for sidelining Hungary. The EU has initiated numerous infringement procedures and brought cases before the European Court of Justice (ECJ) to challenge Orbán's anti-LGBTQ+ policies and other breaches of EU law.[11] In 2018, the EU invoked